populist grievances; instead, it obscures IO engagement, potentially deepening public perceptions of IOs as distant and unaccountable if word of such backroom engagement leaks out.

Indeed, when IOs actively intervene in domestic politics, such as by withholding funds from populist governments to favor opposition parties, they risk further exacerbating political tensions. These actions can reinforce populist claims of IO interference and sovereignty violations, further entrenching anti-IO sentiment. While secrecy can help IOs maintain functionality, it is not a panacea. Balancing covert engagement with visible efforts to address populist concerns is essential to fostering long-term cooperation.

6.1 How IOs Sideline Populists' Constituents

Sidelining populists' constituents involves working around the voter base that populist leaders rely on, either by obscuring interactions between populists and IOs or by empowering nonpopulist groups. This approach helps IOs maintain functionality while reducing the domestic political costs stemming from populists' engaging with them. By shielding their cooperation with IOs from public scrutiny, populist leaders can avoid alienating their base, while IOs can focus on their objectives without the friction of overt populist opposition. Alternatively, IOs can shift the domestic political balance by bolstering nonpopulist constituencies, reducing the influence of anti-IO voices. We begin with this latter approach before delving into secrecy, which is the focus of our empirical tests in this chapter.

6.1.1 Shifting the Domestic Calculus

IOs can shape domestic politics either deliberately or incidentally. For example, they may provide material benefits to nonpopulist groups, endorse reformist leaders, or promote governance structures that strengthen democratic institutions and weaken populist rhetoric. The EU's support for nonpopulist candidates in Poland, through its strategic withholding of funds from the populist-led government, exemplifies how IOs can leverage their influence to affect domestic politics. By signaling that compliance with IO norms brings tangible rewards, IOs can tilt domestic power dynamics in favor of actors more aligned with their values.